A GIFT OF FIRE THIRD EDITION - SARA BAASE
CHAPTER 3: Technology & Free Speech

Lecture 2

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Anonymity

- True anonymity
  - “Unlinkability”
  - Inability of anyone to determine the true author’s identity
  - Legally problematic



Anonymity

- Pseudonymity:
  - Pseudonymity is the near-anonymous state in which a user has a consistent identifier that is not their real name: a pseudonym.
  - public pseudonyms: link between pseudonym and human being is easy for the public to know or discover
  - non-public pseudonyms: link known by sysadmins, but no one else
  - unlinkable pseudonyms: link not known and not discoverable by service operators

Anonymous Re-mailers and Web Browsers

- Johan Helsingius set up the first well-known anonymous email service in Finland in 1993.
  - Users were not entirely anonymous
  - the system retained identifying information.
  - Return address stripped off and then forwarded to recipient
- To send anonymous email using a “re-mailer” service, one sends the message to the remailer, where the return address is stripped off and the message is re-sent to the intended recipient.
- Anonymous web browsers - hide user’s IP address, do not track or store activity

Anonymity vs. Community?

- Supporters of anonymity
  - Claim that it is necessary to protect privacy and free speech.
  - Helps those who are concerned about political or economic retribution.
    - Human rights workers
    - Victims of domestic violence

Anonymity vs. Community?

- Opponents of anonymity
  - Claim that it is anti-social and allows criminals to hide from law enforcement.
  - Threatens civil discourse (“marketplace of ideas”)
  - Examples:
    - Online harassment
    - Fraud

Spam

- Unsolicited, mass e-mail
  - Is cheap to senders but may impose costs on recipient's time or the recipient's online account (or both).
  - May contain objectionable content (political, commercial ads, solicitations for funds, pornography, etc.)
  - May contain a disguised return address.
  - May pass through filters.
- – Invades privacy.
- – Creates a financial and managerial burden on ISPs.

Spam: solutions (?!)

- Technology: Filters that screen out spam.
- Market pressure: Services that list spammers
- Small “microfee” for sending an email?
- requires consent for email marketing
- Vigilantism: Punish spammers

Thank You